

that separated one from another... I think that's going to breed stability. I look at the next decade as one that has stability, but I look at the efficiency that's been created and engineered into India's airlines to be great for consumers. You'll continue to have some of the best prices in India compared to any other part of the world.

SK: Aviation is a capital-intensive business, and that might put off some potential entrepreneurs. How do you look at the landscape and what would you suggest to someone who wishes to enter the space?

VD: What has happened in Indian aviation is a mirror image of what's happened in US or European aviation. Nothing about that history troubles me... In the US, TWA and Pan Am were household names. And then you had the likes of American Airlines, Delta, United, and Continental that bankrupted these massive, well-run airlines. And then the likes of Southwest came in as low-cost carriers and bankrupted these airlines. And now, through consolidation and restructuring of costs, you've got stability and profitability for a decade. This is exactly the way Indian aviation has played out. Because we have entered this era where we've got consolidation, restructuring of some of the airlines, [and] professional management. I'm very excited that this is going to be stable and great for airlines [in the] long term.

For entrepreneurs looking to get into aviation, I would welcome them. But this is not one for the faint-hearted. You can't look at aviation in terms of quarters. You've got to look at aviation in terms of years.

SZ: What was the thought behind setting up Akasa and what did it mean for all those who decided to back this dream?

VD: Akasa was founded on very simple principles. The fundamentals were that India is incredibly underpenetrated as far as aviation is concerned, with this hard to fathom, unimaginable growth ahead. Yet, we had [only] one or two professionally managed airlines. Having spent 27 years in US aviation, it was

surprising for me to see that in this country of 1.4 billion people. For me, this was a no-brainer that there's a spot here for us to create a third airline that has this massive runway. The only thing was, is this the right time? And there was no better time than Covid to start an airline.... We had availability of aircraft, of highly qualified people, and airports and slots and a slew of other things. There's no other moment in our history when you had that kind of availability, and all you'd have to believe was that the world and the human race would overcome Covid.

SK: Honestly, I think it takes some amount of entrepreneurial spirit to start off during Covid. It takes courage and conviction. Clearly the opportunity was there. The under-penetration was visible. The relative lack of competition was also there. It still took somebody to have the conviction and the capital to start something.

"It didn't take him (Rakesh Jhunjhunwala) long to believe that this was the right time to start the airline because he believed in the India growth story more than anyone. And the rest is history"

SZ: How has the infrastructure focus of the government helped?

VD: If it were not for policy changes and policy execution and infrastructure investment, I don't think many dreams could be enabled... You can't land a plane without a runway. You need to build runways, terminal capacity, air traffic management capabilities...

Some of the most discouraging things that I heard were, 'Vinay, you don't know anybody.' 'You're a professional.' 'You'll never get a licence.' 'You're too naïve.' 'India doesn't work like this. You've been operating in the US for 27 years. What do you know?'

The fact is that we got our licence in less than two years from inception... Where in the world do you have the efficiency to provide an aviation licence and get aircraft in the air from inception, in less than two years? I want to also [give a] shout out to the efficiency of the bureaucracy and their support, and government policies that are not just associated with brick and mortar and runways and terminal buildings, but even the policies that allowed us to get our licence—without compromising on safety and without knowing anyone.